The Men Who Killed Me

By Marie Louise Niyobuhungiro

Born:1975 (day and month unknown)
Birthplace: Shyorongi, just outside Kigali

MARIE: **(Pgs 29-34)** People think I am crazy because I am always crying, and I do not blame them for thinking so. I am always angry, and I do not sleep at night. I hoped secretly that I would die during the genocide, but being among other survivors within a survivors' organization has brought me comfort and hope. I feel like I have a family now, and I am very grateful for that.

INTRODUCTION

In the 100 days of genocide that ravaged Rwanda in 1994, one million people were killed and as many as 500,000 women and girls were raped. No one was spared. Grandmothers were raped in front of their grandchildren; young girls witnessed their families being massacred before being taken as sex slaves. Nearly all the women who survived were victims of sexual violence or were profoundly affected by it. An astounding 70 percent are HIV-positive. In Rwanda's social and cultural climate, survivors who speak out face discrimination and isolation.

Marie Louis Niyobuhungiro is one of the victims of Rwanda. Bear witness not only to the crimes she and her countrymen endured, but to the incredible courage that has allowed her to survive and flourish.

From The Men Who Killed Me: Rwandan Survivors of Sexual Violence edited by Anne-Marie de Brouwer and Sandra Ka Hon Chu; this is the testimony of Marie Louise Niyobuhungiro

MARIE: Before the genocide, we were a family of eight children—five girls and three boys. I was the fourth child in the family. My father was a teacher, and my mother was a farmer. We lived in Shyorongi, just outside Kigali. There were many Tutsi families in Shyorongi; we had only one Hutu neighbour. Although he was our neighbour, that Hutu hated us, especially my father, because we were Tutsi. In 1991, my father was poisoned, and I suspect that the Hutu neighbour who hated him so much did it. When my father started to feel sick, he went to a traditional clinic. After his death, my mother asked the people at the clinic what my father

had died of, and they told her that he had been poisoned. Today, our former Hutu neighbour and all his family are in prison for crimes they committed during the genocide.

On April 6, 1994, when President Habyarimana died,. almost three hundred Tutsi had found refuge in the Catholic church of Mboza.

We arrived at the church at about ten in the morning, and a few minutes later the Interahamwe and far soldiers started shooting. They had guns and shot all the men. I fell, and some dead bodies fell on top of me. I was all covered with blood. I heard screams and babies crying, but I was unconscious for most of the time the attack was continuing.

The next day, they came back to kill those who were not yet dead. There was blood all over me, and the killers thought that I was dead, too, so they left me there, lying among those dead bodies. Once I had regained consciousness, all I could see were a lot of bodies lying around the church. The stench of blood was thick in the air. Except for one of my sisters, all my other relatives died during this attack at the church. Out of three hundred people in the church, only five had survived. I felt completely empty. I had no thoughts and felt nothing, nothing at all.

After the Interahamwe left the second time, I left the church. My sister and I went in different directions, because we felt that even if one of us was killed, the other one might have a chance to survive. I fled in the direction of a nearby forest and ran into an Interahamwe on the road, who asked me where I came from. I recognized him as a fellow churchgoer named Ntirenganya. I told him that I had lost my way and was just wandering around. He said that he had finished killing for the day, so others would kill me, not him.

After that close encounter, I spent three days hiding in the bushes. On the fourth day, I went to the house of an uncle, who had not yet had an opportunity to flee, because his wife had just given birth. He and his wife had already been warned by their neighbour, an Interahamwe, to leave their house immediately; they would not have much longer to live otherwise. Together with my uncle's relatives, I left his house that night. But, at the gate in

front of his house, we ran into a group of Interahamwe militia. They took the girls among us and brought us to a nearby roadblock in order to kill us.

Every far soldier or Interahamwe we met on the way made an insulting speech or had a rod to beat us with. One of them said that the girls should be brought to the Twa, who were often ridiculed in Rwanda and considered stupid and worthless. At some point, a far soldier picked me out of the group and took me to a nearby bush. I don't know what happened to the other girls I was with.

This soldier raped me. After he was done with me, he took me to a house and told the owners of the house to keep me safe, so that he could rape me every time he came. He told them if anything happened to me he would kill them. Every time he came to the house after that, he took me to the forest to rape me. Over five days, I was raped five times a day. The rapist didn't say anything to me. In the forest, the local people often saw me being raped by this man. The local people, an Interahamwe militiaman and other Hutu would watch the soldier rape me and did not even raise their little finger to stop it. They didn't care, because I was Tutsi. They were silent. The far soldier who did this to me was so old -- about forty -- and so savage. It was the very first time I saw what a man was capable of doing.

After those five days, the old man brought me to a lady called Mukandoli, who was an Interahamwe too, and I stayed there. She didn't care about my situation. She didn't say anything, except when she sometimes ordered me to go out and farm. I stayed with this lady for one week. Then another far soldier came and told Mukandoli that his colonel wanted me.

When I arrived at the far camp, the colonel had the "manners" to ask me if I wanted to sleep with him. But I knew that whatever answer I gave, the outcome would be the same, and that I would end up in his bed if he had one. I said no and ran into the bushes. His soldiers spent the whole night looking for me, but they didn't find me.

A little later, I saw a house and entered it. The house appeared to be an Interahamwe's harem, full of Tutsi women and girls. There were about ten teenage girls in the house, all between about sixteen and twenty years old. The far soldiers who were looking for me found

me there and took me back to the colonel. On the way back, they asked me to sleep with them. I told them I could do that the next day. While they were still discussing this, I managed to escape, and I walked all the way to Ruhengeri, which was already under the control of the RPF.

For two weeks, I hid myself during the day and walked during the night. I ate nothing and hid in the bushes. When the RPF went to Kigali, I followed them. I walked just behind them, back to my place of birth. I occupied a house that belonged to owners who had fled the country, because my family house had been destroyed during the genocide. To make a living, I dug the fields for a farmer. Later, a fund for survivors was established, which provided me with a bit of support. I lost four brothers and sisters during the genocide, and one sister died of kidney failure right afterwards. Before the genocide, I had never been intimate with a man, and yet now I have gotten to know many without my consent. Even after the genocide, in 2000, a neighbour came to my house, forced my door open and raped me. There was no use screaming, because no one lived close by. I became pregnant as a result of this rape, and the child died immediately upon birth. The doctors then pressured me to take an HIV test, and I discovered I am HIV positive.

I live in very bad conditions because I didn't go to school. I have no job and am too weak now to dig the fields. I get food from an organization that helps me to survive. I have had four children since the genocide, all from different fathers. The father of one of my children is a neighbour, and the others have jobs in the neighbourhood. I never see them. I only had sex with each of them once. Luckily, my oldest three children are not HIV positive, but my youngest child has not been tested yet. I wish I could give my children some more support, including buying them school materials and clothes. I am always sick, sometimes because of HIV and other times because of the beatings I endured during the genocide. I was hit on my knees and head with a club and I suffer from severe headaches now. I don't think I can forgive the far soldiers or the Interahamwe. I don't want to hear about reconciliation. I accused them in the *gacaca* courts, including the one who raped me, those who participated in the killings in the church and those I saw at the roadblock, but now they are being

released. *Gacaca* courts do not bring justice. I think the best punishment those men could get is the death penalty, because they killed others, too. We need justice.

The ***génocidaires*** should not be released. I shared my testimony in order to help establish justice, and I hope it will do that.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Marie Louise Niyobuhungiro
Book: The Men Who Killed Me: Rwandan Survivors of Sexual Violence (Anne-Marie de Brouwer and Sandra Ka Hon Chu, eds) Pgs 29-34
ISBN: 978-1553653103
Publisher: Douglas and McIntyre
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2009

AWARD HISTORY

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